Monday Night Footballers

Commentary

By Jim Nunnelly

Ralph Brown - Good Learner, Good Teacher

Ralph Brown is the owner and operator of the Sportsmen's Barber Shop at 59th and Swope Parkway. For years he's been at the same location, since 1967 - cutting hair, talking sports and applying all those important lessons on life. He seems really pleased with all his learning.

Let's look at little closer and trace the key learning events in Ralph Brown's life -- his early influences, the opening of his barber shop, his sports travels, and his confrontations of an unpleasant tragedy.

Born and raised here in Kansas City, Brown has several early influences. Besides his late parents, David and Lucille Brown, several others played a major role in shaping Ralph's childhood years. There was Miss Eley, Miss Greenwoood, Miss Hardy, Mr. & Mrs. Mack. They all made sure Brown went to church. They were members of the old Pleasant Green Baptist church at 14th & Woodland.

And of course at school, he respected Chester Anderson, his industrial arts teacher at Lincoln. Brown calls Dr. Anderson "a great influence on my life". As did many others, he was a parent to Ralph Brown and always "pushed" him to succeed - on up until 1954 when he graduated. After school, he left Kansas City in a hurry.

The next major lesson in life for Brown was the opening of his own business - The Sportsmen's House of Coiffures in 1967.

Bolstered by his early influences and guaranteed by his apprenticeship training under 'Mr. McFarland" at 18th and Vine, he vaulted into the world of business. But, why the name Sportsmen. He speaks stately when he tells about the name.

Well, that's where the professional athletes came to get their hair cut. Not only because of the cultural exchange, but Brown's ability to carry on a good conversation about sports and still produce a good haircut.

It was not unusual to see the Chiefs' Bobby Bell or Mike Garrett or Buck Buchanan and the Royals Frank White there - just coming by to talk, to socialize and to share a learning experience from Brown.

Yes, it was at the Sportsmen that your could "get in on the inside" - to hear what really happened at the "big game' often from the players themselves. Everybody went to Brown's 'I'm here to give the best haircut they want. I'm sincere and (after that) they always relax" he said proudly.

A Sports Fan

To demonstrate his genuine interest in sports, Brown makes it a point to go to the Super Bowl every year. Of the twnety championship games, Brown has seen 17 in person - not bad for a guy who "made it" because people like Chester Anderson and the ladies from Pleasant Green church kept "watch" and taught him well.

Of all the Super Bowl sites, he likes New Orleans best. Attending three games in the world-famous SuperDome, he saw this year's contest between the Bears and the Patriots. But the game he enjoyed most was the 1970 Super Bowl between the Kansas City Chiefs and the Minnesota Vikings. He smiles widely when he talks of the Dawson-to-Taylor touchdown pass. He says that pass-run was the most memorable play in the 23-7 Chiefs victory.

Personal Tagedy

Now, let's see again how Ralph put his learning to work - this time on the negative side. Like all of us, he had to face a personal tragedy - on a spring day in 1983. As a fire captain, hew as trapped in an attic fire at 52nd and Wornall Road. Here, his soul was tested - for he suffered third degree burns all over the lower part of his body. He was learning all over again. This time from a position of weakness.

He was in intensive care for thirty days, disabled for over a year, and faced with physical and emotional pain every second of that long year. "You ain't seen no hurting till you've been burned," he says.

But, again he called on all those early "teachings" from his parents, his teachers, his church guides and now he has completely

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recovered. He also credits the staff at K.U. medical center for helping him "get back", after almost total destruction. They brought him back mentally and physically.

Now, Ralph Brown enjoys more life and he wears a confident calmness. Now he can be a teacher himself. His lesson to others is to pay attention to your parents, surround yourself with caring influences, try "real hard" to succeed and never let tragedy hold you back. Quite a lesson, Ralph. We all need to learn that.

It's something to think about.

Members: Charles Allen, D.D.S.; C. Ashley; Paul Booker; Tom Brown; Carl Clark; Isaac Gardner, Jr.; Ollie Hubbard; Jim Nunnelly; Jerry Price and Ed West.

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